

Even if you have no desire to pursue a career in academia, research is a valuable skill to acquire. It's much easier to better your life and work more efficiently if you know how to conduct research. Rather than needing to ask someone every time you have a question, research will assist you in resolving issues on your own (and help others in turn). It's a win-win process no matter how you look at it.

Now research could mean a lot of things, from conducting surveys to scientific tests, and going on field trips to gather more data are all examples of research. Despite the fact that these activities are critical for the advancement of human understanding, we will not discuss them here. You will find them in some of the future chapters. This article focuses on familiarising you with the simple process of conducting research. We are breaking the entire process down into seven easy steps. These seven steps are further elaborated inside this FastTrack in separate chapters.

## The Seven Step Research Process

It's easy to become overwhelmed with research, but breaking it down into steps makes it more doable. The research process, involves seven basic steps:

- Picking a topic
  - Make it specific
  - Locate key information sources
  - Collect and organize your data
  - White an article or essay
  - Perform additional research
  - Credit all sources
- Let's take a closer look at each of these processes.

### 1. Picking a topic

Your research will be undirected and inefficient if you don't have a topic. Because you didn't take a few minutes to develop a theme, you'll waste hours perusing dozens of sites.

What methods do you use to come up with a topic? For this, you could always use a mind map. A mind map is a visual tool for brainstorming ideas. The following is how it works:



Don't go on a wild goose chase